Once More, With Feeling

A short, mind-bending, horror mystery adventure for level 9 PCs



Introduction

"...we came in?"

For years, The Slayers of Anaris have maintained a reputation as powerful and heroic hunters of monsters, and protectors of the common folk. Stationed in their spacious mountainside keep, this small band of adventurers has previously saved nearby communities from all manner of threats, from goblins, to giants, to vampires, to dragons.

But today, they face a mystery unlike anything they can recall encountering before. A door in their home that they've never seen before. A secret message left behind by the leader and mentor who mysteriously vanished three years ago. An unfamiliar arcane bunker filled with years of research and scattered notes written in their own handwriting. Mounting evidence of an ongoing war with a world-spanning eldritch horror that camouflages itself within the collective human memoryscape, and defends its turf with aggressive and decisive action.

How many times have they made this discovery before? How long have they been at war with this being? How much of their past have they already lost?

"How do you fight an enemy without ever discovering it exists? How do you win without even realizing you're at war? What do we **do***?"*

About This Adventure

Once More, With Feeling is a short adventure designed to be run in 1-3 sessions. Overall, it leans heavily on the exploration and combat pillars of play, and offers little in the way of roleplay. While the terrible discoveries that the PCs are likely to uncover offer ample opportunity for fun inter-PC interactions and meaningful dramatic character decisions, the PCs will spend the entire adventure in a state of isolation, so there are exactly zero NPCs for them to actually converse with. Mostly, you can expect that the adventure will consist of periods of tense discovery, discussion, and mystery solving, interspersed with horrific combat encounters. The overall tone of the adventure is pretty bleak, as it puts the PCs in a helpless situation against an overpowering foe, and explores the inherent horror of discovering that there are gaping holes in your past memories.

Rather than being an adventure that can be easily dropped into any ongoing campaign, this is specifically designed to be a separate, one-off deal. The backstory of the PCs as members of the Slayers of Anaris dictates years of their past lives, and is integral for laying out the central plot hook, as well as for providing some important context that adds to the thematic gravitas of the adventure: we need to give the players something familiar to latch on to in order to get them invested in the world, so that we can later corrupt it to better unnerve them. A second major concern is that the revelations that the PCs uncover over the course of this adventure fall somewhere between "campaign derailing" and "world ending." It's hard to casually go back to delving the secrets of Undermountain or whatever after you learn that there's an unknowable, otherworldly abomination threatening to subsume the world.

Astute readers will likely recognize that *Once More, With Feeling* draws heavy inspiration from a couple of different sources. Most notably, the core conceit of the adventure is a pretty blatant Dungeons and Dragons-themed rip-off of qntm's Antimemetics Division series on the SCP Foundation (check out "CASE COLOURLESS GREEN" in particular). A number of the quotes in this adventure are pretty much directly cribbed from his work. Many of the themes and abilities featured here are also very reminiscent of those explored in Goblin Punch's classic False Hydra concept. Finally, I've cribbed some of the monster design, art, and aesthetics from Grinding Gear Game's Path of Exile: yes, that is literally just The Elder as a thematically-appropriate boss fight.

Adventure Summary

The adventure begins *in media res*, as the PCs are setting up an ambush to slay a white dragon as it returns to its lair. After what should be an intense but decisive victory (possibly on account of the magical ballista that the PCs have at their disposal), the PCs are free to trek back to their home at Anaris Keep.

Upon arriving back at the keep, the PCs' usual post-adventure celebration is interrupted by an unusual discovery: one of them finds a mysterious door in their keep that was never there before, leading down to a basement that their keep definitely never had. This small basement holds a vault-like entrance to an arcane bunker, and a stone plaque carved with a message from Bartholomew Creedich, the former leader of the Slayers of Anaris who mysteriously vanished three years ago. The plaque cryptically warns that, upon entering the containment bunker, the PCs will have 24 hours to make progress against the monster the Slayers have been hunting.

The bulk of the adventure occurs during the 24 hours that the PCs are locked within this bunker. As they delve through the research notes left behind here (most of them written in their own handwriting), they'll discover than Bartholomew built this bunker years ago, in order to combat a powerful eldritch being that has stealthily infested their world, and lashes out against those who can see through its psychic defenses. Those who learn about or otherwise perceive this being are attacked, and ultimately erased from the living memory of others. As the PCs uncover the truth about their situation, they'll start being periodically attacked by vicious aberrations

By the way, that cover art comes from Grinding Gear Games, and their concept art for Path of Exile's "War for the Atlas" expansion.

that emerge from spontaneously appearing grey portals. The more they learn, the more frequent and vicious these attacks become. Now knowing what they know, the only way for the PCs to safely leave the bunker once their 24 hours is up is to use the device at the bunker's entrance to completely erase their memories of everything they've learned here.

In addition to an overwhelming and disorganized pile of research notes and observations to dig through, the PCs will also have the opportunity to complete the last steps necessary to craft a *gem of seeing*. Although the item has limited charges, it will allow them to temporarily pierce the psychic veil concealing their foe, and directly confront the evidence of all the people and things that have been removed from their memories. The most obvious hidden clue is the dozens of dead bodies of former Slayers of Anaris scattered throughout the bunker, but perhaps more important are the journal and other belongings left behind by Nadarr Travek, their long-forgotten second-in-command.

The conclusion of the adventure is left fairly open ended, as the PCs are free to determine for themselves how best to tackle this difficult situation. A TPK within the bunker is probably a worst-case scenario, but would be entirely fitting with the dark and oppressive tone of the adventure. A more likely and more neutral ending would be for the PCs to accomplish what they can during their time in the bunker, and make preparations to aid their future selves the next time the cycle repeats and they enter the bunker again. Alternately, it would be entirely valid for them to decide that this whole situation is bullshit, torch the place, and try to break the cycle before wiping their memories and walking away.

However, there is one potential "bonus ending" available for players who are able to put together the clues, and are willing to take a risk: Bartholomew Creedich built a duplicate bunker in another wing of Anaris Keep, in which he has been constructing a device potentially capable of directly harming, or even destroying, this enemy. If the PCs figure this out, find a way to leave the bunker with their memories intact, and survive long enough to make their way there, one of them will have the opportunity to sacrifice themselves to (maybe) save the world.

PC Level Considerations

I've designed this adventure to be run for a group of five level 9 PCs. This provides a sort of sweet spot, where you can introduce the PCs as badass, larger-than-life, dragon-slaying heroes, but then still put them in a situation where they are completely outmatched and in over their heads when fighting against a world-spanning eldritch horror. However, other than the balance of the monsters and encounters as listed, nothing about this adventure really needs to be tied to that exact level.

If you're willing to rebalance the combat encounters, you could certainly run this for more or fewer PCs, or at a different level. As a lower limit, you may eventually find a point where it doesn't make sense for the PCs to have the resources they do: why do these beginner adventurers already have a keep to themselves, and how could they reasonably craft of *gem of seeing*? As a higher limit, you'll eventually have to contend with higher level spells, which vastly open up the scale of the PCs' potential actions. I haven't done an exhaustive search to see which specific spells might be problematic, but a major general concern would be being forced to confront how this eldritch threat effects other planes and the gods themselves. I think it's much more interesting to leave that as a big ominous question mark.

Other PC Guidelines

While PCs of any class can fit just fine in this adventure, the story here really does rely on there being at least one PC who's a full spellcaster, or at least proficient in Arcana and capable of casting spells. Because many of the plot-critical clues presented in this mystery come from the analysis of magical items and effects, you sort of need at least one PC to funnel that information through. A wizard or artificer would be ideal here, but a bard, cleric, sorcerer, or warlock could certainly work in a pinch. Most parties will naturally gravitate towards having at least one spellcaster, so I don't think that this really a huge concern, but if all of your players just happen to roll up with fighters and barbarians, you might need to intervene.

Also, magic items are cool, and you should definitely let the PCs have some at the start of the game. I'd recommend at least one rare item per PC, but you're not going to break anything if you want to be more generous than that. You should also take the opportunity to make it clear that these items were crafted by Bartholomew, and specifically gifted to each PC. This is a super cheap and easy way to put old Bart in the players' good graces, and give his disappearance some actual emotional weight.

Backstory

As this is ultimately an open-ended mystery, the two most important thing for you to know as the DM are "what do the players know?" and "what is actually going on here?" In other words: I have some pretty in-depth explaining to do here. Bear with me.

What You Tell the Players

Here are the things that the players need to know in order to make their characters and jump into the adventure. You could very reasonably just copy and paste this bit to hand out to them.

Slayers of Anaris. You are all longtime members of the Slayers of Anaris, a group of adventurers dedicated to slaying monsters, protecting the surrounding towns, and keeping the nearby roads open to travel. The organization was founded over a decade ago by an aged human wizard by the name of Bartholomew Creedich,



This is supposed to be Bartholomew Creedich. It obviously isn't my own artwork: I stole it from Francis Tsai, from his work for Wizards of the Coast in "Mysteries of the Moonsea."

who recruited you, trained you, and served as your longtime leader and mentor.

Bartholomew Creedich. "Old Bart" Creedich could generously be described as eccentric. He was a brilliant wizard, a master of enchantment magic, and a notable crafter of magic items (many of which are still in your possession). Bart was honestly a difficult man to talk to, given how he was a know-it-all who delighted in being two steps ahead of any conversation, but he was also a caring and empathetic mentor (or maybe even father figure?). Nothing epitomizes the man better than the various memories you have of him cackling madly as some unexplained contingency plan of his foiled the plans of the monstrous quarry of the month, and led the Slayers to yet another victory.

Roughly three years ago, Bartholomew just up and vanished, leaving behind no clues as to where he went to, or why. Since then, you all have struggled to uphold the mission of the Slayers of Anaris, while completely failing to make any headway into solving the mystery of his disappearance.

Anaris Keep. This sturdy stone structure overlooks a seldom-traveled mountain pass. Although it has long been used as the home base of the Slayers, Anaris Keep has always been fairly empty and underutilized, and has felt even more so in Bartholomew's absence. Today, you all enjoy your own personalized rooms, and have spacious common areas for meals, training, and recreation, but even still, a full wing of the keep is more or less completely unused.

What Is Actually Going On

Background. Roughly seven years prior to the start of this adventure, Bartholomew Creedich first started noticing the presence of something nefarious affecting his memories and encroaching on reality. The details of this unlikely discovery are left to the imagination of the DM and players, but the end result is that Bart succeeded in secretly building an arcane bunker under Anaris Keep to conceal himself from this being. The bunker could only maintain its protective wards for one day per month, so he was forced to adapt a strategy of asynchronous research: he and his trusted second-in-command, the dragonborn wizard Nadarr Travek, would enter the bunker and accomplish what they could during each 24 period, take copious notes, and then erase their own memories before leaving the bunker. They set up contingencies to ensure that, every month, they would rediscover the bunker for the "first" time, and continue their work where they left off.



Here's a nice view of Anaris Keep. Alternately, it's just an art asset that I blatantly cribbed from InnoGames' browser game Tribal Wars 2.

The Enemy. The being in question has no name, but can best be described as "an eldritch horror from outside of reality, that is threatening to invade and destroy all life as we know it." It projects a powerful glamer, which prevents its presence from being noticed by most people. If gazed upon by divination magic powerful enough to pierce its veil, or even just logically deduced by someone intelligent enough to conclude its existence from the sparse clues it leaves behind, it automatically detects this, and instinctually lashes out by summoning otherworldly horrors to attack. The more you know about it, the harder it tries to kill you. Those killed by it are erased from the memories of others, veiled by the same glamer that protects the being itself. Such victims are completely forgotten by their friends, and even rationalized away by their families and significant others.

The Other Slayers. The Slayers of Anaris used to be large and prosperous organization, with over one hundred active members. Unfortunately, during the time that Bartholomew and Nadarr were engaging in their secret monthly asynchronous research sessions, other Slayers were independently piecing together this mystery, and, without the bunker's protection, were subsequently attacked and erased from everyone else's memories. By the time Bartholomew was able to recognize and contain the information breach, the Slayers had been reduced to only about two dozen members, and Nadarr could be counted among the casualties. Or at least, he would be if specific memories and evidence of the fallen weren't still being actively concealed.

Plan B. After coming to the uncomfortable realization that both his group and his memories had been gutted, Bartholomew recognized that he was losing his war, and would need to dedicate more time to fighting this otherworldly being if he was going to keep up with its growing power. Three years prior to the start of the adventure, he finished the construction of a new and improved bunker under the now empty wing of Anaris Keep, and permanently sequestered himself there to begin work on an experimental "silver bullet" device that might be able to permanently kill, or at least wound, his quarry.

However, before hiding away in his new bunker, Bartholomew thought it would be prudent to safeguard against the possibility of him failing. He put a plan into action to ensure that the remaining Slayers would be able to stumble upon the original bunker, pick up his old notes, and begin working in parallel to fight back against their shared foe, using the same one-day-a-month system of asynchronous research.

Final Developments. Since then, the ranks of the Slayers of Anaris have slowly and silently dwindled, as the eldritch horror has grown in strength, and the protections provided by the first vault have become increasingly unreliable. Today, the PCs are last surviving members of the group, and their progress has been noticeably hampered by the actions on one Lady Avalia: about two years ago, this former Slayer was the final survivor in one of the 24-hour bunker research sessions, and decided to destroy as much of the collected information in the bunker as she could, before getting killed herself. She reasoned that, since this foe only attacked those who learned about it, destroying all information about it was the easiest way to save the remaining Slayers.



No, this is fine. Everything is going to be fine, don't worry about it. This friendly piece of Path of Exile fanart comes from wacalac.

The Actual Adventure

Starting the Game

Once everyone has had time to fill out their character sheets and familiarize themselves with the player-specific background information, you can jump right into the first encounter.

The Slayers of Anaris are on the hunt again. A white dragon has recently made its home in the mountains around your keep, and the surrounding towns have entreated your group to deal with the situation. Having tracked this dragon back to its foggy mountaintop layer, you've waited for it to leave on its daily hunt, and are preparing an ambush for when it returns. With your trusty arcane ballista *at the ready, you're hoping to make short work of this dragon.*

Casual Dragon Slaying

Summary: at the start of the adventure, the PCs are set up to ambush an incoming **adult white dragon** outside of the entrance of its lair.

The PCs will have ample time to plan and set up this ambush, so feel free to show them the battlemap ahead of time, and allow them to place themselves and their *arcane ballista* as they please. The entire mountaintop here is shrouded in a thick layer of fog: creatures treat areas more than 400 feet away from themselves as lightly obscured (granting disadvantage on Wisdom (Perception) checks that rely on sight), and areas more than 800 feet away from themselves as heavily obscured (which blocks vision entirely, and effectively grants the Blinded condition to creatures trying to see in that area).

The dragon makes no attempt at being stealthy, so the PCs will automatically notice it as soon as it comes within 800 feet of them. If the PCs make an attempt to hide themselves, the dragon's passive Perception will allow it to spot a PC from 800 feet out if any of their Dexterity (Stealth) rolls are below 16, or from 400 feet out if any of their Dexterity (Stealth) rolls are below 21. Either way, the dragon is aggressive and not particularly bright, and will attack on sight. *The arcane ballista* comes with a convenient camouflage tarp, and uses the Dexterity (Stealth) or Wisdom (Survival) roll of the PC manning it to contest the dragon's passive Perception.

Arcane Ballista

Large object

Armor Class: 15
Hit Points: 75
Damage Immunities: poison, psychic

This enchanted ballista was created by Bartholomew Creedich, the former leader of the Slayers of Anaris. The ballista is considered a magical ranged weapon, with which the PCs are proficient. A creature manning the ballista can fire it as an action. After being fired, it cannot be used again until a creature uses an action to reload it, choosing from one of the below options.

Standard Bolt. *Ranged Weapon Attack,* range: 200/800 ft., one target. A creature hit by a standard bolt takes 4d10+Dex piercing damage.

Net Shot. *Ranged Weapon Attack*, range 150/600 ft., one target. This specially crafted bolt unfurls into a weighted, iron-reinforced net upon being fired. A creature hit by a net shot has its speed reduced by half until the start of its next turn. In addition, it must succeed on a DC 15 Strength saving throw or be grappled. As an action, a creature can retry the saving throw, ending this effect on it on a success.

Tether Shot. *Ranged Weapon Attack,* range 100/200 ft., one target. This barbed bolt is attached to a nearby boulder by a sturdy chain. A creature hit by a tether shot takes 2d10+Dex piercing damage, and becomes tethered to the boulder. While tethered, it is unable to move more than 200 feet away from it without first removing the bolt or breaking the chain.

So Why Bother With This Dragon?

You might notice that this dragon encounter has exactly nothing to do with the rest of the plot. Certainly, if you were trying to cut this adventure down to fit a single session, this fight would probably be the first thing on the chopping block. That being said, I do think that this introduction serves two important purposes. First, introducing the PCs as Big Damn Heroes enhances the horror of then immediately putting them in a confusing and helpless situation, against an overwhelmingly powerful foe. Second, this gives the players some time to get into character and maybe even roleplay a little bit. The more they flesh out their PCs' personalities, quirks, and skillsets, the better you'll be able to specifically tailor the notes left behind by their past selves to match their individual characters, which helps to boost the creepiness factor.



Talk about a great place to slay a dragon. This lovely bit of art, dubbed "At Mountains Feet," was created by one Josu Solano.

Arriving Back Home

The trek back to Anaris Keep in uneventful, but takes two full days. Allow the PCs to take a long rest here.

Upon arriving back at Anaris Keep late in the evening, the PCs are free to celebrate however they like. They might fire up the hearth and cook a hearty meal, break out the good booze from the pantry, retreat to their personal rooms, or any options the players might come up with. At any rate, let them take their time to relax and settle down before you throw them the next plot hook: one of them finds a new door in hallway on the bottom floor of Anaris Keep:

This door would be mundane and innocuous, save for one uncomfortable truth: you've been living in this keep for years, and there's definitely never been a door here before.

Bunker Entrance (1)

The door in question reveals a set of stairs that lead down to a previously unknown basement. The most striking feature in this 25x15-foot stone room is the massive, 8-foot diameter iron vault door. carved with glowing blue runes. A plaque on the side wall reads as follows:

My fellow slayers,

I understand that you likely find your current situation unnerving, but it is vitally important that you follow my instructions to the best of your abilities. I cannot explain more here, but we are hunting the most dangerous and devious quarry in the history of our organization. You will find more answers inside the containment vault.

Upon entering, the doors will close behind you, and you will not be able to leave until the exit sequence automatically initiates 24 hours later. Do not miss this window. Do not bring rations with you in excess of what you will need for this 24-hour period. Under no circumstances should you take anything out of the vault.

Good luck

-Bartholomew Creedich

If the players take the time to investigate the room using something like *detect magic*, they can pinpoint two magical effects. First there a *programmed illusion* spell on the plaque: when a creature exits the vault, it will trigger to alter the plaque's text (see Exiting the Bunker on page 16). Second, the vault door radiates an aura of abjuration magic. By using an *identify* spell (or, if you're feeling generous, succeeding on a DC 20 Intelligence (Arcana) check), the PCs can learn that the runes on the door are part of a powerful spell effect that protects against divination magic.

While the vault door appears massive and heavy, it will gently glide open when pulled with even the slightest force, revealing the Memory Airlock within.

Keeping Track of Time

As the plaque indicates, the rate at which time passes is a key component to this adventure: The PCs only have 24 hours inside the bunker, so time is a valuable commodity to track. All of the relevant time-consuming tasks that the PCs might engage in, such as short or long rests, studying notes (see Handling Research, page 11), or crafting items (see Gem of Seeing, also page 11), have durations measured in whole hours, which should help keep things simple. Assume that the PCs have some way of accurately keeping time as the adventure unfurls.

Memory Airlock (2)

Bartholomew designed this small, 15x15-foot room in order to carefully control who can enter and exit the bunker. A second inner vault door mirrors the one used to enter the room from the outside, and the room's only other notable feature is the cloudy, dark blue glass orb situated on a plain stone pedestal in the center of the room.

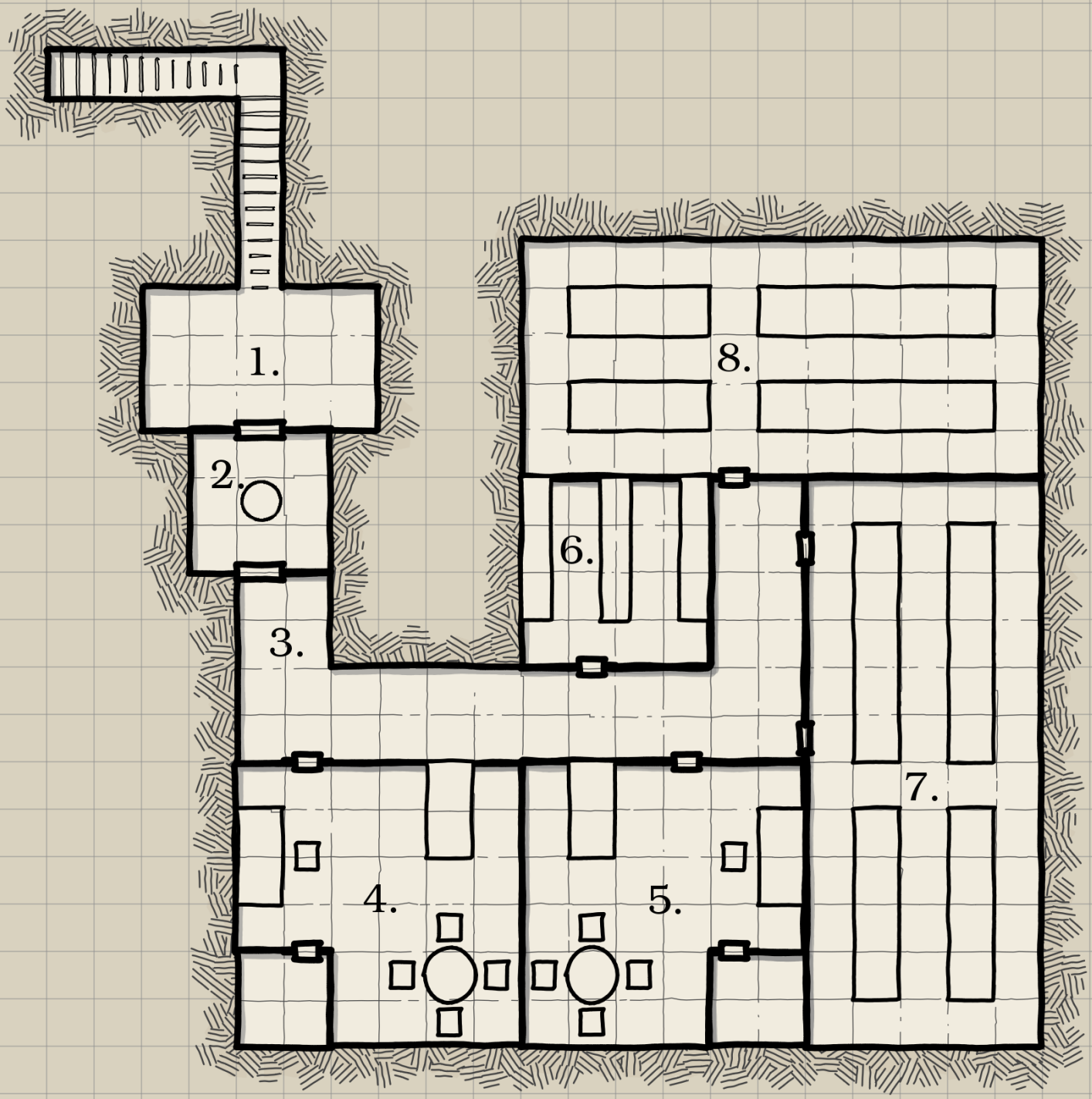
The inner door remains locked until the outer door is closed and secured. At that point, the inner door will automatically open, allowing the PCs to enter the rest of the bunker. The outer vault door will only open again once 24 hours have passed, the inner doors have been closed, and the orb has been activated.

When activated, the orb casts an empowered version of *modify memory* on all creatures within 30 feet of it who don't have total cover. Affected creatures immediately lose all memories of the past 24 hours, and then lose their memories again after 10 minutes have passed. Creature who choose to resist this affect can do so by succeeding on a DC 17 Wisdom saving throw.

With the Gem

Once the PCs finish crafting the *gem of seeing* (see Gem of Seeing, on page 11), activating and looking through it will reveal the direct physical evidence of the former allies who have been erased from their memories. Within the Memory Airlock are the dead bodies of two former Slayers of Anaris. The PCs will likely find many such bodies throughout the bunker, so I haven't taken the time to give each of them a distinct description (a random PC generator would be a great tool if you wanted to add that level of detail). That being said, all of the bodies down here have clearly met a violent death in battle, and appear mummified, rather than showing any signs of decomposition: even the worms and flies have forgotten their existence.

Here's a quick map of the bunker, made easy courtesy of ProbableTrain's Dungeon Scrawl.



Entrance (3)

The walls an either side of the hallway directly past the Memory Airlock are lined with six total stone plaques, identical to the ones found at the Bunker Entrance. Unfortunately, these plaques have all been smashed and defaced to the point of complete illegibility.

There are two pieces of parchment unceremonious pinned to one of the destroyed plaques. Here's the contents of the first page:

Hi [PC #1], Hi [PC #2]. Hi [PC #3]. Hi Richter. HI [PC #4]. Hi Me.

I know this is sort of a shitty situation for you right now, but if it's any consolation, you've gotten through this before.

As best as we can put together, this bunker was built by Bartholomew years ago, but it's hard to pin down exactly when, and whether it was before or after he disappeared. There is a very real danger here that we're working to fight back against, and we're trying to pick up on Bart's previous work, but someone went and torched a lot of his notes for some reason, so we're stuck trying to bootstrap from stuff we've apparently figured out since then.

The following page has more details about the threat we're facing. DO NOT LOOK AT IT NOW. Take as much time as you need to explore this facility and form your own opinions first. Once you read the next page, the timer starts ticking.

- [PC #5]

Here's what the second note says:

This isn't really a containment vault, it's a shelter. The threat is outside, and we're assuming the worst-case scenario that whatever is out there is close to omniscient and omnipresent. This vault might be the only place in creation that it CAN'T see.

The thing is somehow fucking with memory. Everyone's memories. It's not invisible, but it's protected by some sort of glamer that makes it impossible to notice. That might be for the best: when you do see it, it can also see you. The more you learn about it, the better it can aim its crosshairs on you. I'm afraid that giving it a name might escalate things, so I'm going to just keep using vague terms. I don't think it's sentient, but it does instinctually lash out at those who perceive it, and it is incredibly lethal. I think it can also erase its victims from memory. Why else would the seven of us live in such a large keep? How many of us did there used to be?

It's the perfect cloaking mechanism.

Now that you know this, it knows about you. It will be coming. The orb in the vault will probably erase your memories of this, and make you invisible to it again. That's your escape mechanism. You'll probably come back later to pick up your work where you left off. I don't even know how many times we've been back here.

- [PC #5]

Reading the Second Note

As the previous note hints, reading this parchment is inherently dangerous, as it contains enough concrete information about the nature of the threat to immediately put the PCs on its radar. In a way, you can treat the PCs decision about when to read this as a sort of difficulty slider for the adventure.

If they read the note relatively early (say, within the first four hours of entering), they'll quickly learn what's going on here, and have plenty of time to make informed and targeted quarries from the other clues scattered throughout the bunker. However, it also means that the first combat encounter will happen sooner, and they will have to face more (and more challenging) encounters overall. If the PCs hold off before reading this note (say, at least eight hours), they will conversely face less of a challenge before the end of the 24-hour cycle.

With the Gem

Viewing the empty hallways of the bunker with the *gem of seeing* reveals a gruesome sight: the corridors are filled with dead bodies. There are 17 of them in total, and like the two bodies that can found in the Memory Airlock, these are the remains of former Slayers of Anaris who have been violently killed by eldritch horrors and erased from the PCs' memories.

One of the bodies in particular is notable: a half-elf knight in ornate plate armor died with a piece of parchment still clutched in her hands. This is what Lady Avalia wrote down:

My name is Lady Avalia.

Fuck this. It doesn't make any sense that I would come here alone, but I'm alone now, and all I can remember is my companions who aren't here with me.

I've killed the last of them for now, but they're on to me, and I don't have much time before I can leave. Bartholomew might have tried to set us up here to fight a war, but there is no war. We've lost the war. It's over. This is the mopping-up operation. The only reason we still exist at all is because Bartholomew had the forethought to use magic to constantly erase our memories. Because that's all you can do when you see it: run away and try to forget what you saw. And even that apparently can't work every time. It's circling in. We meet it over and over again and we don't realize it. There's no way we can stop ourselves from rediscovering it!

...Unless there's nothing left here to rediscover. If this knowledge is such a risk, why are we hoarding it here? Why preserve such a dangerous secret?

I'm going to destroy as much of it as I can, so that no one else has to suffer through this.

My name is Lady Avalia. Please don't forget me too.

First Bedroom (4)

Each of the rooms in the bunker is labeled with a conveniently pinned note.

This room might be important. Try not to disturb anything.
- [Any PC]

This room is a comfortable and immaculately clean bedroom, featuring a desk, a table with chairs, and a neatly made bed. In the far corner, a nearly empty closet contains only one of Bartholomew's signature green robes.

After the bunker's initial construction, Bartholomew claimed this room as his own. Since he packed his bags and moved into his new bunker three years ago, the subsequent slayers who have made their way here have all left the room largely untouched, hoping that there might be some clue here that might point to Bart's location. Unfortunately, no such clues exist, but it's a nice thought.

With the Gem

The *gem of seeing* reveals no additional clues here.

Second Bedroom (5)

It seems we've made ourselves at home here. You might as well too.
- [Any PC]

This room's layout and furniture is nearly identical to the other bedroom but appears to be much more lived in: the bed is unmade, the furniture is out of place, and the dust is a lot less built up. A completely blank book has been stashed away in the desk drawer, and in the closet, the PCs can find some trinket or piece of clothing that one of them misplaced a few weeks ago.

While Bartholomew claimed the first bedroom, this room served as the refuge for Nadarr Travek, former second-in-command of the Slayers of Anaris. Since his untimely demise at hands of the being he was attempting to study, he has been completely forgotten, and evidence of his existence can no longer be reliably perceived. As such, the next group of slayers to make use of this bunker didn't give this room nearly as much reverence as Bart's, and started the practice of using this room as a comfortable common area and place of rest during their 24-hour ordeals in the bunker.

About Rests

You might want to think carefully about how you handle short or long rests during the course of this adventure. It's entirely reasonable that the PCs will try to take a short or long rest during their stay here. However, if they put it off for too long, their rest is likely to be interrupted by one (or more) attacks. In addition, the rests that the PCs complete will drastically affect the number and difficulty of encounters that the PCs will be able to survive over the course of this adventure: feel free to balance things on the fly to account for this.

With the Gem

By using the *gem of seeing*, the PCs can find the dead bodies of two more anonymous Slayers of Anaris unceremoniously laying in a corner of the room. In addition, the gem will allow the PCs to see that the book here is not actually blank, but instead is the personal journal of one "Nadarr Travek." If studied, the contents of the journal can potentially reveal some important clues, as described in the Handling Research section on page 11.

Storage Room (6)

I guess this is for us? Take what you need.
- [Any PC]

This small storage room holds multiple floor-to-ceiling shelves, filled with all manner of potentially useful supplies. One shelf is dedicated to the storage of blank parchment, ink, and writing utensils. The other two contain an eclectic mix of assorted materials: precious gems, preserved monster parts, dried herbs and other plants, various minerals and metals, and all manner of strangely colored liquids in nearly labeled jars. Various notes pinned to the shelves list a meticulous inventory of the entire contents of this room, conducted by several of the PCs during their past trips here. With a DC 10 Intelligence (Arcana) check, the PCs can deduce that this represents a fairly comprehensive catalogue of spell components and materials for crafting magic items.

With the Gem

Looking around the storage room with the *gem of seeing* reveals a number of previously hidden notes. They are pretty much all just redundant inventories of the room, accomplished by a sequence of killed slayers.

Laboratory #1 (7)

We're calling this room "Lab #1."
- [Any PC]

This expansive room once served as Bartholomew's personal laboratory. However, the room has clearly seen better days: the walls are marred with ash and scorch marks, and much of the equipment strewn across the benches here is broken.

The benches here are covered with research notes, roughly organized into separate piles. These notes are all written by the PCs, and their contents are explored in the subsequent "Handling Research" section on page 11.

With the Gem

The *gem of seeing* reveals no clues of import in this room. There are several hidden notes written by late members of Slayers of Anaris, but they only recap information laid out in the other, more easily accessed notes in the room.

Laboratory #2 (8)

And this is "Lab #2."
- [Any PC]

This room appears to be nearly identical to the other laboratory, save for the fact that it lacks any noticeable battle damage, and the equipment here is largely intact. This includes alchemist's supplies, glassblower's tools, jeweler's tools, smith's tools, and tinker's tools, as well as specialized equipment for crafting magic items.

The Gem of Seeing

Other than the research notes, the most notable object in this room is the delicate stand holding a nearly completed *gem of seeing*. The item consists of a precisely carved diamond lens, a gold encasement inlaid with magical runes, and wooden wand-like handle. Reading the surrounding notes (once again, explained in the "Handling Research" section below), reveals that the *gem of seeing* has been an ongoing project, and is nearing completion. In fact, the PCs are able to finish crafting the item today, provided that they spend roughly 4 hours completing the final incantations, and expend a 4th-level spell slot.

With the Gem

The *gem of seeing* reveals no additional clues in this room.

Handling Research

The vast pile of notes left behind in the research labs contains a plethora of clues to help the PCs figure out what exactly is going on here. However, they are too numerous and disorganized to be comprehensively read within 24 hours, so the PCs will have to be selective about what they try to look in to. With one hour of effort and a successful DC 15 Intelligence (Investigation) check, each PCs can uncover one relevant clue or note. If a PC fails the check, the DC for their subsequent checks in this category is reduced by 5. This reduction is cumulative, and lasts until they succeed on a check.

Alternately, a single successful check will allow the PCs to index the notes, and split them into the following categories. After this, subsequent checks should be dedicated to one topic of discovery.

About the bunker

The protective abjurations surrounding this bunker are ingenious. The anti-divination effect is too powerful to maintain indefinitely, so this protective spell is designed to only work periodically. The bunker slowly charges arcane energy over a month-long period, and then expends that energy to power its protections for 24 hours. That cycle must be synchronized with whatever wards normally prevent us from discovering this basement in the first place.
- [Any arcane spellcaster PC]

A Note About Notes

These notes are designed to be handed out the players to provide some direct quotations from the notes PCs are perusing, and supplement the more general information narrated by the DM. Rather than just handing them out as-is, you'll definitely want to take some time to tailor them do your specific PCs. I've put various parts of the notes [in brackets] to indicate places where you should substitute in their names, with suggestions as for which class or type of character would be appropriate for that note. I would also highly recommend dropping some trivial notes here, along with some "bombshells:" have the PCs' past selves mention names that the players don't recognize, but are implied to be past teammates, siblings, significant others, etc.

Multiple notes here express concerns over the efficacy of the bunker's protections.

I've double checked the wards lining the bunker, and I didn't find any evidence of physical damage or arcane weakening. If they're not working as well as they used to, it's not because anything has changed here: it must be that whatever's on the outside is pushing harder.
- [Any arcane spellcaster PC]



Here's a gem of seeing. *It's literally just the picture of the* gem of seeing *from the 5e "Dungeon Master's Guide" (you know, the one from Wizards of the Coast).*

The Memory Airlock

The orb in the center of the memory airlock is a magical item capable of removing memories from a victim's mind.

This memory removal is apparently a necessary condition for leaving the bunker safely. If you want to survive, don't fight it.

The orb will automatically activate after 24 hours have elapsed since entering the bunker. There is an audible, 20-second warm up period before the device fires.

The orb requires a direct line of effect to function. Simply covering the orb with a blanket or something would be sufficient to protect someone from its memory-wiping effects. Obviously, doing such would be a very bad idea.

Okay, so hear me out. The airlock configuration out there isn't necessarily tied to a 24-hour cycle. If we really wanted to leave early, we could probably hot-start the process by introducing a controlled burst of arcane energy into the system as follows...
- [Any arcane spellcaster PC]

(With this knowledge, a PC can use their action to touch the orb, and expend a 3rd-level spell slot to trigger the airlock's exit sequence at any time.)

What Are We Fighting?

Many of the notes allude to *something* out there, slowly encroaching into the Prime Material plane unnoticed to anyone. It is purposefully not given a name.

Several of the notes here describe the concept of "reciprocal sight." In short, this obscure arcane phenomenon describes a situation where perceiving or gaining knowledge about something also informs that thing about you. If you gaze for long into an abyss, the abyss gazes also into you.

The monsters we're fighting obviously aren't natural. It doesn't even seem like they're real. We took the time to dissect a couple of them before their bodies vanished, and they don't have any organs or discernable working anatomy. They've got mouths and teeth, but no actual digestive systems. Some of these things shouldn't even be able to swallow. It's like someone just took the vague idea of a monster and brought it to life.
- [Any PC with Medicine or Nature proficiency]

A log of attacks and incursions. There's variation between the logged events, but the trend is that they're happening earlier and earlier during the 24-hour period, and seem to be getting more dangerous in the later stages.

How do you fight an enemy without ever discovering it exists? How do you win without even realizing you're at war? What do we do?
- [Any PC]

How Can We Fight Back?

While [Wizard] is working on his arcane brute-force solution, I've been thinking of more subtle tools we might be able to develop. Mental checklists, or mantras, or exercises for spotting the gaps in our memories. This thing might be able to erase people from our memories, but clearly its methods aren't foolproof. It's still possible for us to at least deduce the existence of gaps in our memories, and use logic to try to fill in the gaps.
It seems like the major barrier here is recognizing that anything is missing in the first place. If we can build up the habit of rationally analyzing our situation, and train ourselves to reflexively notice any discrepancies in our memories, we might be able to better equip ourselves to plot of the boundaries of this thing's influence.
So, here's what I propose: Read this. Memorize it. Meditate on it. Commit it to the deepest recesses of your memory. Make it second nature to you. Make a habit of considering this, and earnestly meditating on the answers:
"I might be under the mental control of a hostile being.
What am I trying to accomplish? Why I am trying to accomplish it?
Where am I? Does it make sense that I'm here? What steps led me here?
What..."
- [High Wisdom PC]

Other than this note (and those found in Nadarr's journal), there are no indications of anything that could actually fight back against this being.

The Gem of Seeing

Ok, so apparently something out there is eating our memories and trying to keep us in the dark. I say "fuck that." With the components stashed here, I think we should be able to craft an item capable of piercing pretty much any sort of deception, illusion, or glamer. We don't really understand what exactly is going on now, but maybe we would if we could see what we were missing.
- [Any arcane spellcaster PC]

Here are the steps involved in crafting the item: please check them off as they are completed.
First, craft a 200 carat or greater diamond into a lens with the following dimensions...
- [Any arcane spellcaster PC]

(The *gem of seeing* is nearly complete. Any spellcasting PC can spend 4 hours and expend a 4th-level spell slot to follow the last few remaining steps and finish constructing the item.)

Nadarr's Journal

Nadarr's journal initially appears as a blank book to the PCs. Its contents can only be discovered and investigated by using the *gem of seeing*. Because it's just a single book, each check into Nadarr's journal takes only 10 minutes: the length of one charge of the *gem of seeing*.

Do you see? It's a defense mechanism. This information-swallowing behavior is just the outer layer, the poison coating. It protects the entity from discovery while it infests our reality. And as years pass, the manifestations will continue, growing denser and knitting together... until the whole world is drowning in them, and everybody will be screaming 'Why did nobody realize what was happening?' And nobody will answer, because everybody who realized was killed, by this system...

If something can cross over from conceptual space into reality, taking physical form, then something can cross in the opposite direction. It must be possible to take a physical entity, mechanically extract the idea which it embodies, amplify that idea and broadcast it up into conceptual space. A bigger idea. A better idea, one designed specifically to fight this thing. An ideal. A movement. A hero.

The notes here lay out a magical device apparently capable of "extracting" and "broadcasting" an idea from a living being. This device is entirely theoretical, without even a proof of concept to back it up. If this theory even works, it would require years of research and construction, as well as a massive area to construct the memory amplification arrays: at least three times as much area as contained in this bunker.



This is a riftling
(Image credit: Daren Horley)

The Monsters

Throughout the adventure, there are only four monster statblocks that you'll need to use. Unfortunately, I made the decision early on in the development of this adventure to leave all of them as nameless, unknown horrors: I thought it would be a really cool effect to have their names appear in Roll20 as just incomprehensible symbols. I still think that that was a great decision, but it does make it sort of hard to write about them. In order to make life a little easier, here are some real actual English names for the monsters I'm about to describe:

- ❀ꘋ𐊧↕˩ ᵑʏ, or **riftling**
- ﻩ✗˜‡◊⁞ ⁻ʏ, or **giant fuckoff spider**
- ᴛ◌ᔑ˚ ˛◌, or **the Lonely**
- **Harbinger of** ᛉא❀ῶ‡≚ᛝ, or just **harbinger**

Riftlings

Each **riftling** (or ❀ꘋ𐊧↕˩ ᵑʏ) consists of a fleshy body, roughly the size of a human torso, from which sprouts a uniquely disorganized arrangement of claws, spines, tendrils, and limbs. They walk, crawl, or pull themselves towards their prey using whatever appendages happen to be closest to ground, and then fling themselves onto their target, attempting to latch on and tear away at their flesh.

❀ꘋ𐊧↕˩ ᵑʏ

Medium aberration, unaligned

Armor Class 14 (natural armor)
Hit Points 32 (5d8 + 10)
Speed 30 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
17 (+3)	15 (+2)	15 (+2)	3 (-4)	12 (+1)	10 (+0)

Skills Perception +3, Stealth +4
Senses passive Perception 13
Languages —
Challenge 1 (200 XP)

Pile On. The ❀ꘋ𐊧↕˩ ᵑʏ has advantage on attack rolls against a creature if it or another ❀ꘋ𐊧↕˩ ᵑʏ is attached to it.

Actions

Claw. *Melee Weapon Attack*: +5 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. Hit: 10 (2d6 + 3) slashing damage and the ❀ꘋ𐊧↕˩ ᵑʏ attaches to the target. While attached, the ❀ꘋ𐊧↕˩ ᵑʏ moves with the target, and the target's speed is reduced by 10 feet.

The ❀ꘋ𐊧↕˩ ᵑʏ can detach itself by spending 5 feet of its movement. In addition, a creature that uses its action and succeeds on a DC 13 Strength (Athletics) or Dexterity (Acrobatics) check can detach 1d3 ❀ꘋ𐊧↕˩ ᵑʏs from itself or a willing creature within 5 feet.

Giant Fuckoff Spiders

This monstrosity appears as a massive spider akin to a daddy long-legs. It's so large that its body is compressed against the ceiling, and its legs are forced to bend at odd angles in order to fit within the confines the room. Speaking of legs, it has way too many of them. Or maybe too few? It's actually pretty difficult to keep track of the legs, since the spider's body seems to be constantly retracting legs into itself and extruding new ones as it maneuvers around the room.

The **giant fuckoff spider** (or ᔓᚷᖘᚿᚾᚴᚤ) uses the stats of a **kruthik hive lord** (*Mordenkainen's Tome of Foes*, page 212). If you don't have that book, an **otyugh** would also work fine.

The Lonely

This is literally just **the Lonely** from *Mordenkainen's Tome of Foes* (page 232). He's a creepy-looking grey dude with an unidentified black fluid leading from its eyes, and arms that extend to 60-foot long harpoons. I'd also describe his movements as jerky and unnaturally fast, like a silent film character brought to life.

I personally decided to just ignore the Thrives on Company trait, since I didn't feel it was super relevant to the monster's lore in this particular incarnation, but you do you.

The Harbinger

The **Harbinger of** ᛉᚸᚹᛟᛏᛗᚢ is the closest thing to a "final boss" in this adventure. However, don't feel constrained to make this a unique monster: if the PCs defeat it once, a second one might attack later. Or two at the same time, if you're feeling particularly vengeful.

Its stats are a pretty blatant reskin of the **star spawn larva mage** from *Mordenkainen's Tome of Foes* (page 235), with just a couple of tweaks to make it thematically appropriate.

At first glance, the being is a humanoid figure wearing a tattered grey robe. At second glance, a number of unsettling irregularities become apparent. Even in its hunched posture, the being is roughly 10 feet tall. It has not two, but four arms, which are each inhumanly long and have two distinct elbows. There are no legs or feet extending from the bottom of its robe, but instead a mass of writhing grey tentacles. Its face is largely obscured by a low-hanging hood, but underneath that you can only make out a gaping maw filled with sharp teeth.

Harbinger of ᛉᚸᚹᛟᛏᛗᚢ

Large aberration, unaligned

Armor Class 16 (natural armor)
Hit Points 184 (16d10 + 96)
Speed 30 ft., fly 30 ft. (hover)

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
17 (+3)	12 (+1)	23 (+6)	18 (+4)	12 (+1)	16 (+3)

Saving Throws Dex +6, Wis +6, Cha +8
Skills Athletics +3, Stealth +5
Damage Resistances cold; bludgeoning, piercing, and slashing from nonmagical attacks
Damage Immunities psychic
Condition Immunities charmed, frightened, paralyzed, petrified, poisoned, restrained
Senses darkvision 60 ft., passive Perception 16
Languages —
Challenge 16 (15000 XP)

Innate Spellcasting. The harbinger of ᛉᚸᚹᛟᛏᛗᚢ's innate spellcasting ability Charisma (spell save DC 16, +8 to hit with spell attacks). It can innately cast the following spells, requiring no material components:

At will: *eldritch blast* (3 beams, +3 bonus to each damage roll), *minor illusion*, *modify memory*
3/day: *antipathy/sympathy*
1/day: *circle of death*

Actions

Slam. *Melee Weapon Attack*: +8 to hit, reach 10 ft., one target. Hit: 7 (1d8 + 3) bludgeoning damage plus 13 (3d8) psychic damage, and the target must succeed on a DC 19 Intelligence saving throw or be poisoned until the end of its next turn.

Tendril Field (Recharge 6). Each creature of the harbinger's choice within 10 feet of it must make a DC 19 Dexterity saving throw. On a failure the target takes 22 (5d8) pyschic damage and is blinded and restrained by dark spectral tendrils. An affected creature takes 22 (5d8) pyschic damage at the start of each of the harbinger's turns. The creature can repeat the saving throw at the end of each of its turns, ending the effect on itself on a success.

Legendary Actions

The harbinger of ᛉᚸᚹᛟᛏᛗᚢ can take 3 legendary actions, choosing from the options below. Only one legendary option can be used at a time and only at the end of another creature's turn. The harbinger regains spent legendary actions at the start of its turn.

Move. The harbinger moves up to its speed without provoking attacks of opportunity.
Cantrip (Costs 2 Actions). The harbinger casts one cantrip.
Slam (Costs 2 Actions). The harbinger makes one slam attack.
Feed (Costs 3 Actions). Each creature restrained by the harbinger's Tendril Field takes 13 (3d8) psychic damage, and the harbinger gains 6 temporary hit points.

Combat Encounters

Generally speaking, the pace of the combat encounters in this adventure should be determined by how quickly the players figure out what is going on here. The nice thing about telling this story as a tabletop RPG is that you can listen in as the players discuss the clues they find, and accurately keep track of exactly how much they know. The ultimate goal here is keep the PCs on their toes, and ramp up the difficulty of the fights as they learn more about their foe.

Also, don't feel too compelled to use these encounters exactly as is. Feel free to add or remove monsters, or give some of these combats multiple waves of enemies. Especially if the PCs decide to use some of their valuable time to rest, you might need to crank up the difficulty a notch or two.

Encounter #1: Just Eyes

Okay, this one isn't actually a combat encounter: it's just the first warning shot. Shortly after the PCs either read the read the second page of the entrance note, or do enough research to start figuring out what's going on, read this to them:

As you look up from the note you're reading, something catches your eye. There, on the wall across from you, is a large, monochrome grey eyeball. It blinks once, then turns to focus on you. A moment later, that wall is covered in similar grey eyes, all intently watching you and your companions. Several seconds later, all of the eyeballs simply disappear.

Encounter #2: Riftlings

Roughly two hours after the eyeball incident, or whenever is narratively appropriate, things get real when the PCs are attacks by 6 **riftlings**.

Suddenly, an oval portal appears on the wall. It's a dull metallic grey, and ripples like liquid metal. From this tear in reality, a fleshy, appendage-covered being tumbles into the room. Simultaneously, five more entities appear from identical grey portals.

Encounter #3: Escalation

Next, the PCs are attacked by 4 **riftlings** and 2 **giant fuckoff spiders**. They also appear out of thin air from mysterious grey portals.

Encounter #4: More Creep

More portals, more problems. This time, its 5 **riftlings** and 1 **the Lonely**. A second **the lonely** will appear 1-3 rounds into the encounter.

Encounter #5: Harbinger

There's only 1 **harbinger** and 3 **riftlings** for this fight. That should be enough to put some fear into the hearts of the PCs.

Encounter #6: The End

2 **harbingers**. This encounter is a TPK waiting to happen. Save it for when the PCs are moments away from escaping the bunker. Or if they delved too deep and too quickly into the information contained in the bunker, and are gunning for a tragic ending.

Encounter #7: ᛉᚾᛟ᛬ᛞ

Uh oh.

Okay, Let's Be Assholes

Running a one-shot with disposable PCs offers some unique opportunities to you as the DM. In particular, a one-shot means that you don't need to be concerned with the long-term health of the PCs, and you can be much freer with afflicting them with permanent and debilitating effects. Given that this adventure revolves around monsters who can remove victims from living memory, wouldn't it be cool if the monsters here could simply erase parts of the PCs' pasts? Here's what I recommend: every time a PC fails a saving throw against a **harbinger**'s slam or **the lonely**'s Sorrowful Embrace, or just takes damage from the **harbinger**'s Feed action, delete something from their character sheet. Maybe a skill proficiency, a known spell, or a ribbon class feature. Don't announce this, just quietly alter their character sheet. If the player tries to use a removed ability, look at them with a confused look on your face and say "[Feature]? No, [PC name] has never had [Feature], what are you talking about?"

How to Conclude This

For the most part, this adventure ends when the PCs either exit the bunker with their memories wiped, or die fighting within the bunker. These are the points where the players' knowledge diverges from the PCs' knowledge (or, you know, everyone dies), and are both perfectly acceptable endings.

That being said, there are a variety of clues laid out here that could potentially lead to a more optimistic ending. Here's the intended train of thought:

- Many of the former slayers killed by this thing have been removed from their memories.
- The PCs can still remember Bartholomew: he must have somehow avoided being killed.
- Nadarr hypothesized a device that could potentially destroy their foe, but would require years of research, and a much larger laboratory space.
- Bartholomew has been missing for several years.
- A much larger laboratory space potentially exists in the unused wing of Anaris Keep.
- Therefore: Bartholomew is (maybe) still alive, and has been working on constructing this countermeasure in the other side of Anaris Keep.
- If the PCs can leave the bunker with their memories intact, they might be able to find him.

Don't feel compelled to lead your players to this conclusion. It's great if they figure that out on their own,

but otherwise the other adventure endings are perfectly acceptable.

Exiting the Bunker

The first obstacle the PCs face in reaching the second bunker is leaving the first one with their memories intact. If the players have taken the time to research the workings of the Memory Airlock, they should know that this is as easy as covering up the memory-wiping orb prior to activating it. Alternately, they might simply power their way through, and hope that at least one PC passes their saving throw to resist the effect, circumvent the issue by using a spell like *dimension door*, or find some other creative solution.

Whether or not the PCs have their memories upon exiting the memory airlock, the only obvious thing that will great them in the bunker entrance is the stone plaque, now showing an updated message:

My fellow Slayers,

Well done! If you're standing here now, you are likely disoriented, but take heart: your work here is now finished. You've done well, and have earned your rest. This transition period will be much less stressful if you simply make your way back to your individual rooms and sleep on the matter.

-Bartholomew Creedich

If the PCs have erased their memories, this message is the concluding note of the adventure. The confused PCs make their way to their chambers, and wake up the following morning with no memory anything unusual happening to them after arriving home at Anaris Keep after successfully slaying a dragon. If the PCs left with their memories intact, they will immediately hear an overpowering psychic roar, coupled with a sensation of external pressure pushing on their heads, and the distinct sensation of the ground rumbling beneath their feet: they (and the knowledge they've pieced together over the past 24 hours) have very viscerally been noticed.

Getting There

The second obstacle is traversing Anaris Keep. Outside of the bunker's protections, PCs who haven't had their memories erased will face the full wrath of their foe. Rather than treating this as a winnable combat encounter (because it isn't), I would treat this as a skill challenge: narrate the PCs' flight through the keep as they barely stay ahead of an unending horde of eldritch monsters. Maybe also give the PCs the choice of taking a shortcut through the courtyard, or staying inside the keep: if the heroes head outside, they will see the sky filled with eyes and grey tendrils, stretching from horizon to horizon.

The Second Bunker

If successful, the PCs can find another bunker, nearly identical to the first one. After entering a similar vault door and memory airlock sequence, they'll find a bunker very similar to the first one, except that it only includes a single bedroom, and has greatly expanded laboratory space. The vast majority of these chambers are filled with arrays of arcane equipment and magical apparatuses: the working components of the idea extraction/broadcasting device Bartholomew built to try to combat his foe.

Bartholomew, unfortunately, did not survive to greet the PCs. His decaying body can be found slumped over a desk, with no signs of injury or physical trauma. A DC 10 Wisdom (Medicine) check confirms that he died of natural causes. The scattered notes on his desk will reveal that the "silver bullet" he constructed is completed and functional, and only requires one last piece: a suitable subject willing to have their essence extracted and broadcast to combat the eldritch terror that has been hunting the Slayers for years. Bartholomew's final notes document his growing insecurities about his compromised mental state, and the compounding and debilitating long-term side effects of frequent memory wipes. Alongside these are vague plans for wiping his memory one last time in order to leave this bunker, bring back the remaining Slayers, and convince one of them to serve as the substrate for the device's activation.

While the idea extraction/broadcasting device is 100% functional and ready to be activated, doing so is no mean feat. Here are the major concerns:

- One PC will need to be hooked up to the device to be idea-ified. This requires that they be restrained by the various tubes and wires they're plugged in to, and will ultimately be fatal. I'm picturing it as a fantasy MRI scanner, but with more torture-ish restraints.
- Activating the device is a drawn-out process, which requires the sequential activation of various switches, levers, and buttons throughout the bunker, with precise timing.
- The abjurations protecting this bunker will fail at a narratively convenient time, so the PCs will have to activate the device during the midst of a final, climactic, and overwhelming fight.
- You're the DM, you can figure out the specifics here.

Depending on how the fight develops, I happen to like the idea that successfully activating the device doesn't have an immediate effect: The PCs can either die in a pointless last stand, or retreat and erase their memories before they learn whether or not their plan actually worked. Does this actually work? That's up to you.



Another piece of Path of Exile fanart, this time from Alex Manis.

Okay, but I'm a Jerk, and That's All Too Optimistic

So, you want a more pessimistic ending? Try this instead: Bartholomew died before he could complete the idea extraction/broadcasting device. There are still months, if not years of research that need to be done before it might be usable. The second bunker here offers better protection than the one they just left, but is still slowly being breached by the overwhelming presence of the eldritch horror bearing down on them. The PCs have earned a short respite, but the attacks here will continue to accelerate until they die or erase their memories.

The climax here is not the PCs vanquishing their foe, but instead them planting the seeds to do so in the future. How will they ensure that they find this bunker again in the future to continue Bart's work, even after exiting the memory airlock and forgetting about all of this? What contingencies can they lay out for themselves in this short span of time?

If the PCs can escape the bunker alive, then maybe, just maybe, the plans they set in motion will be enough to get them to find this place again (and again, and again), and maybe they can finish this device in time.

Boring Stuff

This is version 1.0 of this adventure, ostensibly 100% complete and ready for you to use. All of this nonsense was put together by me, u/Adam-M, explicitly for you to draw inspiration from and use at your table. If you and/or your group liked this, the coolest thing you could do is send me a message with some feedback and tell me how it went. The least cool thing you could do is repost this somewhere and claim it as your own work. That's a dick move.

"Isn't this where..."